

Stress Free Cat Vet Visit — Action Checklist

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CARRIER SETUP & TRAINING

- ☐ **Carrier Setup & Training:** Move the carrier into a common room with the door permanently Velcro-ed open so your cat stops associating it with vet visits and starts seeing it as just another piece of furniture.
- ☐ **Carrier Setup & Training:** Place a worn t-shirt or your cat's favorite blanket inside the carrier so the inside smells like home and your cat feels more secure when they enter voluntarily.
- ☐ **Carrier Setup & Training:** Feed meals near and eventually inside the carrier, moving the food bowl closer each day and treating your cat every time they enter on their own.
- ☐ **Carrier Setup & Training:** Follow the six-week training plan starting with carrier exposure without pressure and progressing through car rides with the engine on, doing each week in sequence without skipping ahead.

PRE-VISIT PREPARATION

- ☐ **Pre-Visit Preparation:** Spray Feliway Classic inside the carrier 15 minutes before departure to take the edge off mild-to-moderate car anxiety using synthetic pheromones.
- ☐ **Pre-Visit Preparation:** Cover the carrier with a light blanket or towel during the car ride to reduce visual stimulation and create a more enclosed, secure-feeling space for your cat.
- ☐ **Pre-Visit Preparation:** Keep the car cool and drive as smoothly as possible, avoiding hard braking and sharp turns that disorient cats and compound their stress during transport.
- ☐ **Pre-Visit Preparation:** Discuss Gabapentin prescription with your veterinarian before your next visit, as it is a widely used off-label sedative that can make examination possible for severely anxious cats.

VET COMMUNICATION & ALTERNATIVES

- ☐ **Vet Communication & Alternatives:** Tell your vet about every past bad experience including how long the aggression lasted so they can modify their approach and use appropriate handling techniques.
 - ☐ **Vet Communication & Alternatives:** Ask if your vet has a hard-sided carrier with a removable top available at the clinic, since this allows examination without forcing your cat out of their safe space.
 - ☐ **Vet Communication & Alternatives:** Research mobile vet services or at-home vet alternatives for routine care that does not require your cat to travel, eliminating car rides and clinic stress entirely.
 - ☐ **Vet Communication & Alternatives:** Schedule periodic carrier practice drives every few months even when no vet visit is scheduled to maintain positive associations and prevent regression.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.